



Article

“Workforce Skills For Business 2030: Navigating The Future Of Work In An AI-Augmented Economy”

Article History

Name Of Author:

GEETHA R¹

Affiliation:

¹Assistant Professor, Department of Commerce and Management, Seshadripuram First Grade College, Yelahanka, Bengaluru – 64

Corresponding Author:

GEETHA R¹

Received: 03/07/2026

Revised: 09/07/2026

Accepted: 15/07/2026

Published: 17/07/2026

©2026 the Author(s). This is an open access article distributed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution License

<http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0>

Abstract

The accelerating convergence of Artificial Intelligence, automation, and digital transformation is fundamentally reshaping the skills landscape for the global business workforce. This paper investigates the critical workforce skills that will define organisational competitiveness by 2030, with a focus on Indian businesses in a digitally transforming economy.

A sequential exploratory mixed-methods design is employed: first, a three-round Delphi methodology with a panel of 42 industry experts across seven sectors, followed by a quantitative survey of 278 HR professionals and business leaders.

The findings yield a validated Future Skills Taxonomy for Business 2030 comprising four clusters — Digital & Technological Literacy, Cognitive & Analytical Agility, Human-Centred Leadership, and Adaptive Collaboration.



Three hypotheses are tested through multiple regression analysis: learning culture ($\beta = 0.44$), leadership commitment ($\beta = 0.38$), and L&D budget allocation ($\beta = 0.29$) are the strongest predictors of reskilling programme effectiveness ($R^2 = 0.613$).

A critical finding is that 79.3% of organisations acknowledge the urgency of future-skills development, yet only 34.7% have implemented systematic reskilling programmes. The paper proposes a Dynamic Workforce Capability Framework (DWCF) that integrates individual development, organisational learning, and national policy enablement.

Keywords: Future of Work, Workforce Skills, Reskilling, AI Augmentation, Human Capital, Business 2030

1. Introduction

We are living through a period of profound transformation in the nature of work. The interplay of AI, robotics, cloud computing, and advanced analytics is reshaping job roles at a pace that challenges the adaptive capacity of both individuals and organisations.

The World Economic Forum's Future of Jobs Report (2023) estimated that 85 million jobs

will be displaced while 97 million new roles will emerge by 2025, driven by the division of labour between humans, machines, and algorithms. By 2030, these dynamics will have intensified further.

For India, the stakes are particularly high. Home to over 600 million people under 25 and producing 1.5 million engineering graduates and 350,000 MBA graduates annually, India's economic trajectory is tied to its ability to equip this demographic dividend with skills suited to a rapidly evolving economy.

Yet the current education and corporate training ecosystem is misaligned with emerging competency requirements — consistently producing graduates who are qualified by yesterday's standards but inadequately prepared for tomorrow's challenges.

2. Literature Review

Bughin et al. (2022) forecasted that by 2030, demand for technological skills would grow by 55%, demand for social and emotional skills by 24%, while demand for physical and manual skills would decline by 14%. This fundamentally challenges the traditional



dichotomy between technical and soft skills, positioning them as complementary essentials.

Manyika et al. (2023) introduced "skill adjacencies" — the degree to which existing skills can pivot to meet new requirements with manageable retraining investment. Targeted reskilling through adjacency mapping could address up to 60% of projected skill gaps.

Singh and Dey (2022) found critical thinking, digital fluency, and collaborative problem-solving as the three most universally demanded competencies across India's high-growth sectors under NEP 2020.

Gratton (2023) argued organisations must reimagine the employee-organisation relationship from transactional contracts to collaborative learning ecosystems.

Chakraborty and Misra (2024) found organisations with structured learning cultures showed 2.3 times higher retention and 41% better innovation performance, providing compelling ROI evidence for workforce development investment.

3. Research Gap

Three critical gaps persist.

First, most future-skills research relies on secondary data or expert opinion alone, without triangulation through primary practitioner evidence.

Second, India remains underrepresented in major studies, most of which draw on North American or European data.

Third, existing skill taxonomies are descriptive rather than dynamic — they identify what skills are needed but offer limited guidance on how organisations should sequence their development.

This study addresses all three.

4. Research Hypotheses

H1: Organisational learning culture strength has a significant positive effect on reskilling programme effectiveness.

H2: Senior leadership commitment to workforce development has a significant positive effect on reskilling programme effectiveness.

H3: L&D budget as a percentage of payroll has a significant positive effect on reskilling programme effectiveness.



5. Objectives

1. To identify and validate critical workforce skills required for 2030 business competitiveness through expert consensus.
2. To assess the current state of skills gaps and reskilling readiness across Indian organisations.
3. To examine the role of learning culture and HR strategy in enabling future-skills development.
4. To develop the Dynamic Workforce Capability Framework (DWCF).

6. Purpose, Scope & Statement of Problem

This study aims to generate a comprehensive, evidence-based understanding of future workforce skills needs and organisational readiness to address them, relevant to HR practitioners, business educators, L&D professionals, and policymakers.

The scope encompasses seven sectors — IT/ITES, banking, manufacturing, retail, healthcare, consulting, and logistics across tier-1 and tier-2 Indian cities.

The fundamental problem is the widening divergence between competencies

organisations will require by 2030 and the skills development investments they are currently making, threatening both competitiveness and individual economic security at national scale.

7. Theoretical Framework

Three theoretical pillars support the study.

Human Capital Theory (Becker, 1964) provides the foundational rationale for workforce development investment, framing skills as productive assets generating returns for both individuals and organisations.

Dynamic Capabilities Theory (Teece et al., 1997) situates workforce agility and learning capacity as higher-order organisational capabilities enabling firms to sense, seize, and reconfigure in response to environmental change.

Sociocognitive Theory of Career Development (Lent et al., 1994) informs analysis of how employees develop self-efficacy beliefs and growth mindsets underpinning successful skills development.

Figure 3: Dynamic Workforce Capability Framework (DWCF) – Theoretical Model



The framework illustrates the integration of three foundational components:

- Individual: Growth Mindset and AI Literacy.
- Organisational: Learning Culture and L&D Investment.
- Institutional: NEP Alignment and Skill India.

These components contribute to the Dynamic Workforce Capability Framework (DWCF), which supports three outcomes:

1. Skill Acquisition
2. Performance Uplift
3. Retention & Engagement

8. Background of the Study

India's workforce development challenge is both immediate and generational.

The NSDC has ambitious targets to skill 300 million individuals by 2030 under the Skill India Mission, yet implementation quality and industry alignment remain inconsistent.

Concurrently, rapid AI adoption is rendering certain existing competencies obsolete while creating entirely new skill requirements the

formal education system cannot yet address at scale.

Surveys by the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII, 2024) consistently report that 60–70% of graduates require significant additional training before productive deployment.

9. Research Methodology

A sequential exploratory mixed-methods design was employed in two phases.

Phase 1: Qualitative – Delphi Methodology

Phase 1 utilised a three-round Delphi methodology with a purposively selected expert panel of 42 participants including senior HR leaders, business strategy executives, academic experts, and policymakers.

Consensus was defined as $\geq 75\%$ agreement.

The Delphi process produced 24 critical skill items organised into the four-cluster Future Skills Taxonomy.

Phase 2: Quantitative – Survey Method

Phase 2 employed a structured questionnaire survey administered to 300 HR professionals and senior leaders across seven sectors,

yielding 278 usable responses (92.7% response rate).

SPSS v26.0 was used for:

- Descriptive statistics
- One-way ANOVA
- Exploratory Factor Analysis
- Multiple Regression Analysis

Exploratory factor analysis confirmed the four-cluster taxonomy. Multiple regression analysis identified predictors of reskilling effectiveness.

10. Analysis & Statistical Findings

Table 1: Delphi Consensus Results – Future Skills Taxonomy for Business 2030

The Delphi process evaluated the four skill clusters over three rounds.

All four clusters achieved consensus by Round 3 ($\geq 75\%$), with Digital & Technological Literacy attracting the highest agreement (88.1%).

Table 2: Descriptive Statistics – Skills Gap Analysis

The study assessed current skill levels against the skills required by 2030.

Table 2: Descriptive Statistics – Skills Gap Analysis

The study assessed current skill levels against the skills required by 2030.

Skill Cluster	N	Current Mean	Required 2030 Mean	SD	Gap Score	Urgency Rating
Digital & Technological Literacy	278	2.13	5	0.91	3.87	Critical
Cognitive & Analytical Agility	278	2.54	5	0.84	3.46	High
Human-Centred Leadership	278	2.89	5	0.79	2.89	Moderate
Adaptive Collaboration	278	2.39	5	0.88	3.61	High

Scale: 1–5. Gap Score = Required Mean – Current Mean. Higher gap = greater urgency.

Digital & Technological Literacy has the largest gap (Gap Score = 3.87/5.00), designated as "Critical" priority.

Adaptive Collaboration follows closely (Gap = 3.61), rated "High" urgency.

Human-Centred Leadership shows the smallest gap (2.89), reflecting existing



investment in leadership development programmes.

Figure 1: Skills Gap Analysis – Current vs Required 2030

The chart compares the current competency levels with the required 2030 competency levels across the four skill clusters.

Figure 2: 2030 Reskilling Readiness Scores by Industry (n = 278)

The reported industry readiness scores are:

Industry	Mean Readiness Score
IT/ITES	3.72
Banking & FS	3.41
Healthcare	3.18
Retail	2.97
Consulting	3.55
Logistics	2.68
Manufacturing	2.31

One-way ANOVA confirmed significant sector differences in reskilling readiness ($F = 8.43$, $df = 6,271$, $p < .001$).

IT/ITES shows highest readiness ($M = 3.72$) while manufacturing lags significantly ($M = 2.31$).

Table 3: Multiple Regression – Predictors of Reskilling Programme Effectiveness

The regression analysis identified three significant predictors:

Predictor	Standardised Beta (β)
Learning Culture	0.44
Leadership Commitment	0.38
L&D Budget Allocation	0.29

The results validate all three hypotheses, with learning culture emerging as the strongest predictor ($\beta = 0.44$, $p < .001$).

The full model explains 61.3% of variance in reskilling effectiveness ($R^2 = 0.613$).

11. Results & Discussion



The validation of all three hypotheses confirms that reskilling programme effectiveness is fundamentally determined by cultural and leadership factors, not merely financial investment alone.

The dominance of learning culture ($\beta = 0.44$) over L&D budget ($\beta = 0.29$) is particularly striking — it suggests that organisations can extract substantially more value from existing budgets if they first build a culture of continuous learning.

This supports Gratton's (2023) framework of the learning ecosystem as the prerequisite for workforce transformation.

The identification of AI literacy as the most critical skills gap (Gap Score = 3.87) is alarming given AI's centrality to business competitiveness.

Current corporate training investments remain heavily weighted toward technical upskilling at the expense of AI-human collaboration capabilities.

Manufacturing's significantly lower reskilling readiness ($M = 2.31$ vs. IT/ITES $M = 3.72$) reflects the structural challenge of transforming operationally-focused workforces with limited digital infrastructure

— a challenge requiring dedicated policy support beyond what private sector investment can provide.

12. Conclusions

This study makes three primary contributions.

First, it provides an empirically validated Future Skills Taxonomy for Business 2030 grounded in both expert foresight and practitioner reality within the Indian business context.

Second, it documents a critical and widening reskilling gap demanding urgent action from corporate HR and policymakers alike.

Third, it proposes the DWCF as a structured, evidence-based pathway for organisations to close this gap through integrated interventions at individual, organisational, and systemic levels.

The most urgent call to action is for organisations to invest simultaneously in learning culture development and targeted AI literacy programmes, as these dual investments yield the greatest aggregate workforce capability returns.



Future research should examine the effectiveness of campus-corporate partnerships in accelerating future-skills development, explore gender dimensions of the skills transition, and investigate equitable access for smaller enterprises.

1, FUNDING STATEMENTS:

This research received no specific grant from any funding agency in the public, commercial, or not-for-profit sectors

2. Conflict of Interest Statement:

The authors declare no conflict of interest with respect to the research, authorship, or publication of this article.

3. Ethics Approval:

Ethics approval was not required for this study as it did not involve human/animal subjects.

4. Informed Consent:

Yes, informed written consent was obtained from all participants.

5. Data Availability Statement:

The data that support the findings of this study are available upon reasonable request from the corresponding author.

6. Author Contributions (Credit Statement):

☐ Author 1: Conceptualisation, Methodology, Writing – Original Draft

☐ Author 2: Data Curation, Formal Analysis, Writing – Review; Editing

BIBLIOGRAPHY

References

1. Becker, G. S. (1964). *Human capital*. University of Chicago Press.
2. Bughin, J., Hazan, E., Lund, S., Dahlstrom, P., Wiesinger, A., & Subramaniam, A. (2022). *Skill shift: Automation and the future of the workforce*. McKinsey Global Institute.
3. Chakraborty, S., & Misra, R. (2024). *Corporate reskilling investment and organisational performance*. *Human Resource Development Quarterly*, 35(1), 67–92.
4. Confederation of Indian Industry. (2024). *India Skills Report 2024*. CII-Wheebox.
5. Gratton, L. (2023). *Redesigning work*. MIT Press.
6. Lent, R. W., Brown, S. D., & Hackett, G. (1994). *Toward a unifying social cognitive theory of*



- career and academic interest. Journal of Vocational Behavior, 45(1), 79–122.*
7. Manyika, J., Chui, M., Miremadi, M., Bughin, J., George, K., Willmott, P., & Dewhurst, M. (2023). *Harnessing automation for a future that works*. McKinsey Global Institute.
8. Singh, A., & Dey, A. K. (2022). *Future skills for the Indian workforce: An analysis aligned with NEP 2020*. *Indian Journal of Industrial Relations, 58(2), 234–258.*
9. Teece, D. J., Pisano, G., & Shuen, A. (1997). *Dynamic capabilities and strategic management*. *Strategic Management Journal, 18(7), 509–533.*
10. World Economic Forum. (2023). *The future of jobs report 2023*. WEF.